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Mold in schools a growing problem

Climate change intensifying summer storms, causing damage, damp conditions in buildings

By Adriana Pérez
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Instead of returning to familiar hallways and classrooms, hundreds of students from John H. Kinzie Elementary School in Garfield Ridge began their first week of classes this year at the adjacent John F. Kennedy High School.

The students had been moved while the school underwent environmental testing and remediation after mold was discovered in several parts of the building at 5625 S. Mobile Ave. The Chicago Public Schools district began monitoring concerns at the South Side school in early August after receiving reports of musty odors, water damage, peeling paint and possible mold in some parts of the building, according to communications shared with families. On Aug. 31, one week after the first day of school, students safely returned to classes at Kinzie.

In recent weeks, mold has similarly derailed daily activities and operations across several public buildings in the area, including at least a handful of other schools in Chicago, multiple facilities in a southwest suburbs school district, two schools in Mount Prospect and a police station in Waukegan.

As greenhouse gas emissions from human activities like fossil fuel burning increase average global temperatures, summers in the Midwest are becoming more humid. When the atmosphere warms, it can hold more moisture, leading to heavier downpours and local flooding. This causes storm damage and damp conditions in buildings, which can support mold growth and expose humans to bad air quality and health issues.

Because school buildings operate differently in the summer, their air conditioning, ventilation and dehumidification systems remain mostly unused, and water damage likely goes unnoticed without occupants. This puts them at particular risk of developing mold. But the people they serve are also especially vulnerable because of their immature immune systems: Children exposed to mold can develop short- and long-term health issues such as mild allergic reactions, worsening asthma, respiratory infections and severe illness.

"The safety and well-being of

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AMERICA 250 AN ESSAY

Requiem for the American Dream

Tribune photojournalist chronicles a nation in search of its past, with fragile hopes for its future

Photography by E. Jason Wambsgans and Words by Chris Borrelli
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

By some quirk of fate, the 250th anniversary of the country landed at exactly the same moment as a pivotal election that promises, regardless of who wins, to redirect the future of the country. That odd mix of unease, resilience, exhaustion and hope you're feeling right now, one week away from this nail-biting midterm election? That feeling's real. It's not just a bipartisan mood reflected in national polling. And that ambiguity has a face. It arrives having weathered centuries of history. But what does such a mood look like?

Tribune photojournalist E. Jason Wambsgans spent part of the year answering that question and considering the ways that our present is informed by our past. With an assist by features writer Christopher Borrelli, the result is a unique portrait of Illinois, and the nation itself, during a moment of truth. **Essay on Pages A14-A18**



Top: A drone show in celebration of America's 250th birthday in downtown Joliet on June 26. Above: Fireworks on 19th Street in Pilsen on July 4.

INSIDE



E. JASON WAMBSGANS/TRIBUNE

No paved paradise

Some call them Asphalt Hunger Games or the Thunderdome: Why Trader Joe's parking lots are the way they are. We ranked every one in Illinois. **Arts & Entertainment**

Bears stadium becomes political game as midterms near

For GOP, issue is a Hail Mary to find a subject that may garner votes

By Rick Pearson
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

When the topic of a new Chicago Bears stadium came up in their face-to-face forum on Oct. 13, Republican challenger Darren Bailey delivered a shot at Democratic Gov. JB Pritzker: "I'm just glad I'm not going to be known as the governor that lost the Bears."

Bailey later acknowledged the line was a "jab," a sound bite meant for newscasts and social media. But coming from a Republican making his second bid to unseat Pritzker, the phrasing also suggested Bailey wouldn't be the one in the governor's chair if the team left for Indiana.

In recent weeks, the saga over where the Bears will build a new stadium — Arlington Heights, Chicago or Hammond, Indiana — has become more than just a sports bar discussion. For Republicans, and Bailey in particular, it represents a political Hail Mary to find a subject that captivates voters and gets them to vote for GOP candidates.

Pritzker backs "policies that are forcing small businesses and the Chicago Bears to greener pastures," Illinois Republican Party Chair Bob Grogan said in a statement Tuesday. And Bailey told the Tribune Editorial Board earlier this month that his "critique of Pritzker is that he's done nothing" to keep the Bears in Illinois, while Bailey called Indiana, which has dangled a stadium entertainment district package largely subsidized by its local taxpayers, "a pretty amazing state."

As it stands now, separate proposals to keep the Bears in

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WEATHER FORECAST

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